



SALES & PROJECT TIMELINES

The Gantt Tool, in plain English

How to read a project timeline, what every button actually does, and exactly which date to give a customer — without a single spreadsheet formula.

★ Read this first (2 minutes)

This tool builds a **schedule** for a customer build — when the long-lead parts land, when we test, when we ship. It looks busy because it's honest: instead of promising one date it can't keep, it shows a realistic **range** and how confident we are.

THE ONE IDEA THAT MAKES IT ALL CLICK

A project timeline here is a **weather forecast, not a calendar appointment**. A forecast doesn't say "it will rain at 3:00." It says "80% chance of rain this afternoon." This tool does the same thing with ship dates — because on a custom build, the big purchased parts and the testing almost never land exactly on the day you first guessed. So we plan with a range and a confidence level, and everyone stops getting surprised.

You do **not** need to understand the math. You need to read two numbers and know what they mean. That's most of this guide. The rest is "what does this button do" so you never have to ask.

What's in here

- 1 **The 60-second version** — open a chart, read two lines, done
- 2 **Getting around** — the list, opening a chart, and "is it saved?"
- 3 **Reading the picture** — bars, colors, the diamond, and the amber line
- 4 **The three numbers at the top** — the ones you quote
- 5 **The anchor** — the long-lead item everything waits on
- 6 **Risks & "what-if"** — playing out what could go wrong
- 7 **Baseline** — saving the "original promise" and tracking drift
- 8 **Tracking real progress** — marking steps done as the job runs
- 9 **Sharing it & the customer script** — print, and what to actually say

The last page is a one-page cheat sheet. Print it and pin it up.

1 The 60-second version

Someone sends you a chart and asks "when does this ship?" Here's all you have to do:

- 1 **Open the chart** — click its name in the Gantt list.
- 2 **Find the one green box** labelled **80% confident by** (top row, on the right). **That date is your answer.** Read it, say it — you can ignore everything else on screen until you're ready.
- 3 **Want the whole story in a sentence?** The green banner just below spells it out: "If long-lead items arrive by X, the shipment window is A–B, 80% confident by C." Same date, more context.

IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER ONE THING

Quote the **"80% confident by"** date. Not the "plan" date. The plan date is a coin-flip (a 50/50 best guess). The "80% confident by" date has real cushion built in — you'll hit it or beat it 8 times out of 10.

That's it for reading. Everything below is for when you want to understand **why** those dates are what they are, or you need to build or tweak a chart yourself.

2 Getting around

The list page

Go to **Admin** → **Gantt**. You get a list of every project timeline — one row per customer build, showing its ship window, number of steps, and status. Click any row to open it.

Two buttons top-right:

- **New from template** — starts a chart pre-filled with a typical unit build (planning → long-lead parts → testing → production → ship). **Easiest way to start** — you just rename the steps.
- **New chart** — starts nearly blank, for when the job doesn't look like the usual one.

"Is my work saved?" — yes, there's no Save button on purpose

It saves itself, every few seconds. That feels odd if you're used to hitting Save — but you **can't lose your work**. Just watch the little indicator at the top: **Saving...** for a second after any change, then **✓ Saved**. Once it says Saved, you can close the tab.

⚠ **"Wait — can I break it?"** Not really — but because it saves instantly and there's **no undo**, you're always editing the **live** plan everyone else sees. So if you just want to poke around, click **Duplicate** first and play with the copy. To undo a change by hand: drag the slider back where it was, or click a switched-on risk chip again to turn it off.

The four boxes at the very top — Project name, Customer, Start date, Status — are just labels. **Start date** matters most: it's day one, and every date is measured from it, so changing it slides the whole timeline (including dates you may have already quoted).

3 Reading the picture

The chart is a set of horizontal bars. Time runs left → right; the dates along the top are weeks. Each bar is one step, and steps run one after another — each starts when the one above it finishes.

The colors mean something

 **Amber bar — the uncertain step everything waits on**

Long-lead parts, testing. These drive the ship date. Watch them. (The tool calls this the "critical path.")

 **Grey bar — routine step**
A predictable step (planning, paperwork, FAT).

 **Faded dashed tail**
How far a bar could stretch in its **worst** case.
The range.

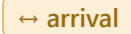
 **Red bar segment**
A "what-if" risk you switched on — extra time from something going wrong (see §6).

 **Green bar — production build**
The step where we actually build the unit.

 **Black diamond — milestone**
A moment, not a task (kickoff, design release, shipment). Zero length.

 **Grey dotted line under a bar**
The **baseline** — where this step was originally planned (see §7).

The amber vertical line

One tall amber line crosses the whole chart with a little  **arrival** tag on top. That's the moment your **long-lead item arrives** — the hinge the whole back half of the schedule swings on. More on that next.

The little bracket around a diamond means that milestone has a window too — it shows its earliest-to-latest. A bar with no faded tail just means that step is predictable (its fast and slow cases match).

DON'T MEMORIZE THE COLORS

The chart has its own **color key printed along the bottom** — glance there anytime. One heads-up: once you set a baseline (§7), amber and red take on a **second** job — a step that's **running late** gets an amber or red **" +X wks vs baseline "** note beside its name. If you see that note, the color means "behind schedule," not "critical path."

4 The three numbers at the top

These three boxes are the whole tool in a glance. Learn these and you can hold any customer conversation.

THE BOX	WHAT IT MEANS	USE IT FOR
Ship window	The realistic range — earliest we could ship, to latest we reasonably would. Not one date. The small "plan" underneath is the middle-of-the-road guess.	Setting expectations: "we're looking at early-to-mid March."
80% confident by	The date you'll ship on or before, 8 times out of 10 . It already accounts for the ranges and the risks. This is the safe promise.	The date you quote a customer.
Vs baseline	How much the plan has moved since you saved your "original promise." Green = on time or better, amber = slipping, red = well behind. Shows "—" until a baseline is set.	Spotting slippage early, before the customer does.

What's P50 / P80 / P90? (the small print under the green box)

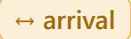
Don't let the codes scare you — the **"P"** just means **"how often you'd make it."** Three levels:

- **P50** = you'd make it half the time. A coin-flip. This is basically the "plan" date. *Never quote it.*
- **P80** = you'd make it 8 times in 10. **The sweet spot for a customer commitment.**
- **P90** = 9 times in 10. Extra cautious — use it for a build where being late would be a really big deal.

RULE OF THUMB

Only ever say the **P80** date to a customer. The plan / coin-flip date is for the shop floor — **never quote it**. That way you look good to the customer and the team stays honest.

5 The anchor — the thing everything waits on

Every build has one step that sets the pace: the **long-lead item** — the big part you order early and wait weeks for. In this tool that step is called the **anchor**, and it's marked with the amber line and the  tag.

Because everything downstream (testing, build, ship) waits on the anchor arriving, moving it moves the entire back half of the schedule. The tool gives you two ways to play with that:

- **The slider** just above the chart — drag it to make the long-lead item take more or fewer weeks.
- **The arrival tag on the chart** — grab it and drag left/right to the same effect. Watch the ship window and confidence dates update live.

Why would I drag it? To answer "what if the vendor quotes 12 weeks instead of 10?" — slide it out two weeks and read the new ship date. It's the fastest way to sanity-check a delivery promise before you make it.

Building your own chart? Here's how to set the anchor: in the task list below the chart, find the **Anchor** column and click the little circle on your long-lead step (the big purchased part everything waits on). There's exactly one per chart. If someone else built the chart, they already picked it — you won't need to touch it.

6 Risks & "what-if" — playing out what could go wrong

Real builds have "if this goes wrong, add three weeks" moments — a test fails, a vendor slips. This tool keeps those **on the chart** instead of in someone's head, so nothing is a surprise.

The risk chips

Under the controls you'll see a row labeled **What-if:** with little chips like **⚡ Testing: test failure · 25%**. Each chip is a named thing that **could** go wrong, with a percentage chance and how many weeks it would add.

By default these do **not** move your dates — they just quietly feed the "80% confident" math (that's how the confidence date already accounts for bad luck).

Switching one on ("assume it happens")

- 1 **Click a chip** (or tick "assume it happens" in the task list). The schedule stretches to show the damage, the affected bar grows a **red** segment, and a red banner appears at the top.
- 2 **Read the new dates.** This is your "if the test fails, here's where we land" answer.
- 3 **Click the chip again to switch it back off** and return to the real plan.

IT'S SAFE TO CLICK — REALLY

Clicking a chip only shows **you** a what-if. Nothing is sent to anyone, and clicking it again puts everything back exactly. A red chart only ever reaches a customer if **you** print it and hand it over. So poke around — you can't hurt anything.

⚠ **Two things to remember** A switched-on risk is a **what-if scenario, not the plan** — the red banner says so on screen and on any printout. And if a chart **already shows a red banner the moment you open it**, someone left a chip switched on and the dates are inflated: find the lit chip, click it off, and check the banner clears **before you quote anything**.

7 Baseline — your "original promise"

A **baseline** is a saved snapshot of the plan the day everyone agreed to it. From then on, the chart quietly shows how far you've drifted from that promise — which is exactly what you want to know before a customer calls.

The three baseline buttons

BUTTON	WHEN TO CLICK IT
 Set baseline	Once, when the schedule is agreed and real. This freezes today's plan as the promise to measure against.
Re-baseline	Only when the plan is officially re-agreed with the customer. It replaces the old promise. Don't do this just to hide slippage.
 (clear)	Rarely — removes the baseline and stops drift-tracking.

Once a baseline is set, two things appear: a faint **grey dotted line under each bar** (where it was originally planned), and the  number lights up. If a step slips, its label shows a small "+2 **wks vs baseline**" note — only when it's actually behind, so a clean chart stays clean.

PLAIN VERSION

Set the baseline when you make the promise. After that, one glance tells you "are we still good, or have we slipped?" — long before it becomes an awkward phone call.

Three things that sound alike — the difference in one line each:

- **Baseline** — the promise you **froze**, so you can see if you've slipped.
- **What-if** — **pretend** something broke, just for a conversation (§6). Not the plan.
- **Assumptions** — the **fine print** that prints with the dates (e.g. "assumes the vendor's 10-week quote holds"). You'll find them in the Assumptions box under the chart.

8 Tracking real progress as the job runs

A chart isn't just a plan you make once — it updates as the build happens, so the ship date gets more certain over time.

In the task list, each step has a **Status**:

- **Not started** — the default.
- **Underway** — work in progress.
- **Done** — finished. When you mark a step Done, it records the **actual** date it finished (you can adjust it). That step becomes a locked fact, and the ship window **narrows** — the more that's actually finished, the less guessing is left.

Why the window shrinks: the guesswork only lives in work that hasn't happened yet. Once the long-lead item has actually arrived, its guess is gone, so the range tightens around a firmer date. When the anchor is marked Done, the amber slider becomes an "arrived" note — it's history now, not a guess. **So keep steps updated as they finish — your quoted dates get more accurate the further along the job is.**

9 Sharing it, & what to tell the customer

Getting a clean copy to send

-  **Print / PDF** — makes a tidy one-page sheet with the ship window, the chart, the risk list, and the assumptions. It **always carries its caveats** — including a "Forecast, not a commitment" footer — so the dates never travel naked. Use "Save as PDF" in the print dialog to email it.
- **Duplicate** — makes a fresh copy, perfect for trying a different plan without touching the real one. Note: a copy starts clean — it carries **no baseline** (set a new one if you want drift-tracking) and any what-ifs are switched back off.
- **Delete** — removes the chart for good. It asks first.

The customer script

✓ Do say

- "We're **80% confident** we'll ship by **[the green date]**."
- "Our window is **[early]** to **[late]** depending on the long-lead parts."
- "If testing needs a second pass, it'd push about **[X] weeks** — here's that scenario." (show the what-if)

✗ Don't say

- "It'll ship **exactly** on [the plan date]." (that's the 50/50 date)
- Quote a **what-if** scenario as if it's the plan. (red banner = not the plan)
- Promise a date **earlier** than the 80% date to win the moment. (you'll pay for it later)

Before you quote it The person who owns the build — usually PM, or whoever set up the chart — is the source of truth for the schedule. If a date looks off, **ask them**; don't hand-edit someone else's live chart to "fix" it. A 30-second check beats an awkward call later.

THE WHOLE JOB IN ONE SENTENCE

Open the chart, read the **green "80% confident by"** date, and give the customer **that** — with the window as context. Everything else in this tool exists to make that one date trustworthy.

Still stuck on something after this guide? That's real feedback — tell us which part, and we'll make the tool or this guide clearer. The goal is that you never have to guess.

Gantt — Quick Reference

Pin this up. Everything you need to read a chart lives here.

THE WORDS

Ship window

Earliest-to-latest realistic ship. A range, not a date.

Plan date

Middle-of-the-road guess. A 50/50 bet. Internal only.

80% confident by (P80)

The date you quote. Ship on/before it 8× in 10.

Anchor

The long-lead item everything waits on. The amber line.

Baseline

Saved "original promise." The dotted line + "Vs baseline."

What-if / risk

A "what could go wrong." Switch on to see the damage; off = the plan.

THE COLORS



Amber

critical path — watch it



Green

production build



Grey

routine step



Diamond

milestone (a moment)



Dashed tail

worst-case range



Red

a what-if switched on

THE "?" ICONS

Hover any small ? in the tool for a plain-English reminder of what that control does.

When a customer asks "when does it ship?" → open the chart → read **"80% confident by"** → give them that date, with the window as context.